

FRAUD ANALYTICS CASE STUDY

The Nizamabad Mule-Account Cyber Fraud Network

From a ₹1.04 Lakh Complaint to a ₹152.18 Crore Network

₹152.18 Cr LINKED TRANSACTION VALUE	46 ACCOUNTS LINKED TO NCRP COMPLAINTS	14 STATES INVOLVED	106 ACCOUNTS REVIEWED BY POLICE
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Real-life Indian fraud investigation | Nizamabad, Telangana

Prepared as an academic case study

Research status: 18 September 2026

Note: This case study analyses the documented investigation. It does not propose or build a machine-learning model.

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Executive Summary

In January 2025, a 32-year-old man in Nizamabad, Telangana, reported losing ₹1.04 lakh through an online investment application that appeared to promise attractive returns. What initially looked like a relatively small investment scam eventually became the entry point into a much larger investigation involving money-mule accounts. Investigators traced the victim's payment to a current account in Nizamabad and arrested the account holder, Mohammad Abdul Jawed. Questioning led investigators to a suspected handler, Gudumala Nithish.

The investigation later expanded during Telangana Cyber Security Bureau's February 2026 Crackdown 1.0. Police examined information associated with Nithish and identified 13 current accounts with transactions of about ₹31.07 crore linked to different cybercrimes. The Nizamabad police then examined 106 current accounts opened at the relevant bank between 2024 and 2026. According to the detailed Indian Express investigation, 46 of those accounts were linked to cybercrime complaints recorded on the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal (NCRP). Those accounts were connected to cases across 14 states, with approximately ₹152.18 crore in linked transactions.

A key feature of the case is that the same mule-account infrastructure could receive money from different kinds of frauds. Reporting linked the central account to investment fraud, impersonation fraud and other cybercrime cases in Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Gujarat and Telangana. This demonstrates why modern fraud investigations increasingly require transaction tracing and cross-case linkage rather than treating every victim complaint as an isolated event.

Key facts at a glance

Item	Documented finding
Initial Nizamabad loss	₹1.04 lakh
Initial complaint	11 January 2025, IV Town Police Station, Nizamabad
Earlier signal	14 June 2024 NCRP complaint involving the same key account and nearly ₹4 lakh from a Noida investment-fraud victim
Key account	56820000100031001 (reported as frozen during investigation)
Accounts found on handler's phone	13 current accounts
Transactions linked to those 13 accounts	₹31.07 crore
Current accounts examined by police	106 accounts opened between 2024 and 2026
Accounts linked to NCRP cybercrime complaints	46
Geographic spread	14 states
Linked transaction value	Approximately ₹152.18 crore
Arrest status in detailed May 2026 report	7 individuals apprehended; 6 account holders reportedly absconding
Important qualification	April 2026 media reports on a related Nizamabad mule-account operation reported 9 or 13 arrests; these appear to cover a related/overlapping operation and should not be treated as a simple replacement for the detailed 46-account case count

Primary detailed source used throughout: The Indian Express, 16–17 May 2026, “1 complaint, a mule account and 14 states: Unravelling of a Rs 152-crore cyber scam.”

Cross-check: V6 Velugu, 9 April 2026, reported 9 arrests in a Nizamabad mule-account operation involving approximately ₹152 crore in transactions; Namasthe Telangana reported 13 arrests in a related report. These reports are treated cautiously because the detailed Indian Express account describes a seven-arrest/46-account investigation.

1. Scope and Methodology

This case study reconstructs a real fraud investigation using publicly available reporting and official cybercrime resources. The objective is to answer the assignment's core questions: what the fraud was, how it evolved, how large it became, how it was discovered, how investigators responded, and what happened to the people involved.

The case is discussed as a Fraud Analytics case study in the broad investigative sense. The term refers here to the analysis of transactions, accounts, relationships and complaint information that helped investigators move from an individual fraud complaint to a wider network. No machine-learning model, predictive score or hypothetical AI detection system is required for the analysis and none is presented as having been used by the police unless a source explicitly says so.

Where the public record contains uncertainty, this report distinguishes between: (a) facts directly reported by police or reputable reporting, (b) allegations or statements attributed to investigators, and (c) analytical interpretation made for academic discussion.

2. What Was the Fraud?

The case was not a single scam operated through a single method. It was a network of bank accounts used as money-mule infrastructure for proceeds generated by multiple cyber-fraud schemes. A mule account is a bank account used to receive, hold or transfer illicit proceeds on behalf of another person or criminal group.

The Nizamabad investigation began with an online investment fraud. The victim was approached through an online investment broker and was reportedly added to a WhatsApp group. He initially transferred ₹5,000 and was shown attractive returns. He then increased his payments, including ₹10,000 and ₹50,000 instalments, until his total loss reached approximately ₹1.04 lakh. When he attempted to withdraw his supposed investment returns, he discovered that the money could not be withdrawn.

The money had already moved into a Nizamabad bank account. Police traced that account, froze it and recovered almost the entire amount of the victim's loss. The account holder, Mohammad Abdul Jawed, was arrested. According to investigators, Jawed identified Gudumala Nithish as the person who acted as his handler. The subsequent investigation showed that the account was not an isolated endpoint.

What is a mule account?

A money mule is an account holder whose bank account is used to receive and transfer money connected to criminal activity. The person may be knowingly participating, may be recruited for a fee, or may in some circumstances be deceived. In this case, police alleged that account holders and handlers were part of a system through which cybercrime proceeds were routed.

For general context, the Telangana Police cybercrime guidance describes a money mule as an account used to receive and transfer illicit money through a chain of accounts.

IAC's National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal maintains a suspect-identifier repository based on multiple public cybercrime complaints, while explicitly warning that entries are not certified findings of guilt and remain matters for investigation.

3. Background and Principal Actors

Actor / element	Role in the documented case
Victims	Individuals in multiple states who were deceived through investment, impersonation and related cyber-fraud schemes.
Fraudsters / cybercriminal syndicates	The parties generating fraudulent transactions and directing proceeds through mule accounts; the public reporting does not establish one single mastermind controlling every fraud.
Account holders / mules	People whose current accounts were used to receive or route proceeds.
Handlers	Intermediaries who, according to police, coordinated account details and connected account holders to cyber-fraud operators.
Mohammad Abdul Jawed	Account holder arrested after the January 2025 Nizamabad complaint; police said his account received the victim's money.
Gudumala Nithish	Identified by investigators as Jawed's handler; his phone data reportedly contained information on 13 current accounts.
Nizamabad Police	Investigated the original complaint, traced the payment, froze the account and arrested initial accused.
Telangana Cyber Security Bureau	Expanded the investigation through Crackdown 1.0 and broader mule-account analysis.
Banks	Held the current accounts through which funds were routed; media reports also raised questions about account-opening and KYC controls.
NCRP / IAC ecosystem	Provided a national complaint and identifier reference point used in linking accounts to cybercrime complaints.

4. Chronology: How the Fraud Evolved

The chronology is important because the case did not suddenly become a ₹152-crore investigation. It evolved through several investigative steps, with the same bank-account infrastructure appearing in more than one cybercrime case.

Date / period	Stage	What happened
14 June 2024	Earlier warning signal	The key account 56820000100031001 appeared in an NCRP complaint involving nearly ₹4 lakh from a Noida investment-fraud victim. The reported investigation did not trace the full network because accounts were spread across states.
2024	Multiple frauds feed the network	Reporting later linked the same account to investment, impersonation and other cyber-fraud proceeds involving victims in different states.
8 January 2025	Nizamabad victim makes payments	A 32-year-old victim transferred approximately ₹1.04 lakh to an online investment scheme after first seeing apparently attractive returns on smaller payments.

Date / period	Stage	What happened
11 January 2025	Police complaint	The victim approached IV Town Police Station, Nizamabad. Police traced the payment to a current account and requested an immediate freeze.
January 2025	First arrests	The account was reported to be in the name of Mohammad Abdul Jawed. Police recovered almost the full amount lost by the victim and arrested Jawed. Questioning led to the identification and arrest of Gudumala Nithish as a suspected handler.
2025	Case initially appears contained	The original investigation was treated as substantially solved, according to the officer quoted by Indian Express. Later investigation showed the account was part of a wider network.
February 2026	Crackdown 1.0	Telangana Cyber Security Bureau launched a broader effort to identify mule accounts, account holders and handlers.
February–2026	13-account link discovered	Information associated with Nithish reportedly contained 13 current accounts with ₹31.07 crore in transactions linked to different cybercrimes.
2026	106-account review	Nizamabad police asked the bank for details of current accounts opened between 2024 and 2026; 106 accounts were examined.
2026	46-account network identified	Police reported that 46 of the 106 accounts were linked to NCRP cybercrime complaints across 14 states, with approximately ₹152.18 crore in linked transactions.
April 2026	Related arrest reporting	Regional media reported 9 or 13 arrests in a Nizamabad mule-account operation involving approximately ₹152 crore. These reports appear to concern a related/overlapping account-selling operation and should be distinguished from the seven-arrest count in the detailed May investigation.
16–17 May 2026	Detailed national exposure	Indian Express published its detailed investigation describing the 46-account, 14-state network and the continuing effort to trace the holder of the key account.
18 September 2026	Research cut-off	No later, case-specific public disposition was identified in the sources reviewed for this case study. The investigation should therefore be described as ongoing rather than closed.

Chronology: How the Fraud Evolved (June 2024 - September 2026)

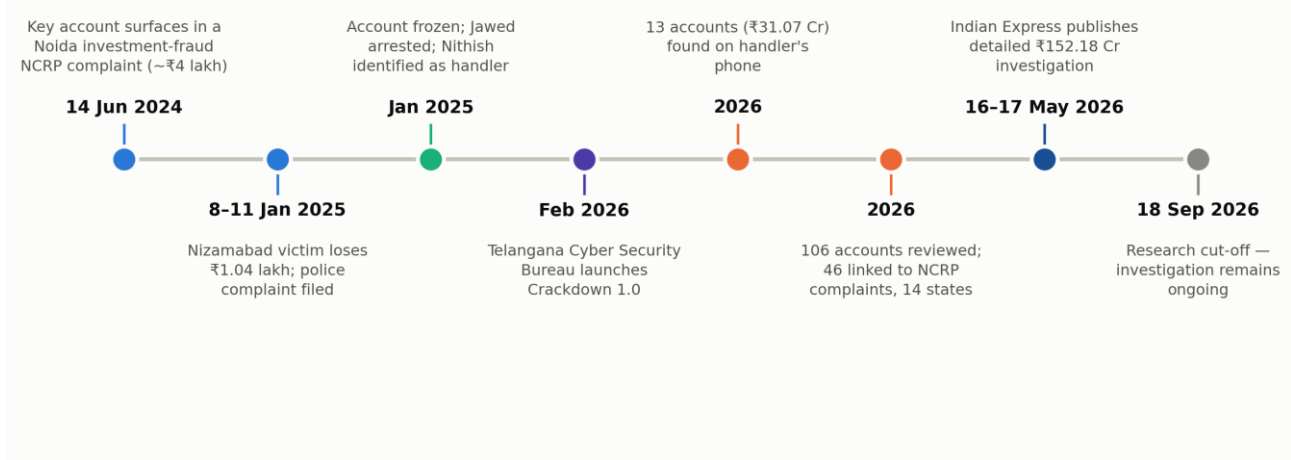


Figure 1. Chronology of the investigation from the earlier Noida-linked signal (June 2024) to the research cut-off (September 2026).

5. Modus Operandi

5.1 Victim acquisition

The documented Nizamabad victim was approached through an online investment opportunity. The alleged fraudster used an investment-broker identity and added the victim to a WhatsApp group. The victim was initially shown attractive returns after a small payment. This reduced the victim's suspicion and encouraged larger deposits.

5.2 Escalation of payments

The pattern reported in the Nizamabad case was incremental. A small initial payment was followed by larger instalments. The victim only realised the fraud after the withdrawal process failed. This is consistent with a common social-engineering mechanism in which apparent early success is used to create confidence before larger sums are requested.

5.3 Use of mule accounts

Once a victim transferred money, the funds did not necessarily remain in the account of the person who communicated with the victim. Instead, the proceeds entered bank accounts used as money mules. Police reporting indicates that handlers could provide account details to different cyber-fraud operators, meaning a single account could receive proceeds from multiple frauds.

5.4 Layering through additional accounts

The investigation found that money moved onward from the central Nizamabad account to other accounts. This created a major recovery problem: by the time police identified an account, the victim's money could already have been transferred further. The same feature also made it possible for one account to appear in multiple investigations.

Simplified Modus Operandi: Money Flow Through the Mule-Account Network



Figure 2. Simplified representation of the reported money-flow structure.

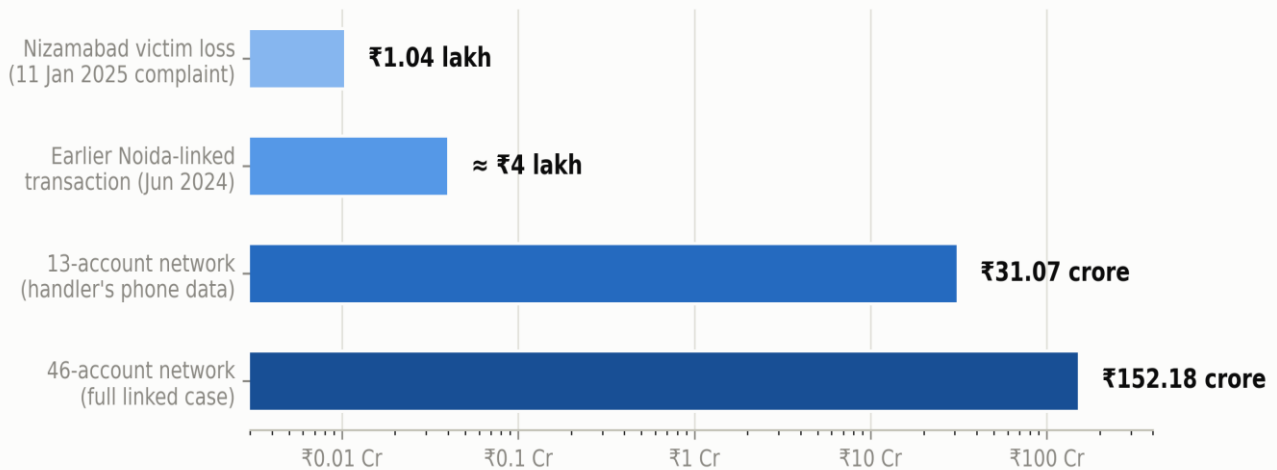
6. Scale of the Fraud

The case's scale should be described carefully. The reported ₹152.18 crore figure refers to the transaction value linked to the 46 identified mule accounts and cybercrime complaints. It should not be described as ₹152.18 crore stolen from one victim or necessarily as the amount retained by a single criminal group.

Measure	Value	Interpretation
Initial Nizamabad victim loss	₹1.04 lakh	The complaint that triggered the detailed Nizamabad investigation.
Earlier Noida-linked transaction	Nearly ₹4 lakh	An earlier cybercrime complaint involving the same key account.
Accounts found in handler's phone	13	Current accounts reportedly linked to ₹31.07 crore in cybercrime transactions.
Accounts reviewed at bank	106	Current accounts opened between 2024 and 2026 that investigators examined.
Accounts linked to NCRP complaints	46	Accounts that investigators reported as connected to cybercrime complaints.
States represented	14	Shows the cross-jurisdictional nature of the network.
Linked transaction value	₹152.18 crore	Reported transaction value associated with the identified network.

How the Case Scaled: From a Single Complaint to a ₹152.18-Crore Network

Value linked at each stage of the investigation (log scale — the range spans lakhs to crores)



Source: Indian Express, 16–17 May 2026 investigation

Figure 3. The reported value linked to the case at each investigative stage (logarithmic scale).

The scale therefore developed in stages: a small individual loss → one identified mule account → multiple accounts → ₹31.07 crore across 13 accounts → 106-account review → 46 accounts linked to cybercrime complaints → ₹152.18 crore in linked transactions across 14 states.

7. How Was the Fraud Discovered?

The discovery mechanism is arguably the most important part of the case from a Fraud Analytics perspective. The network was not discovered because investigators initially had a database showing 46 suspicious accounts. It emerged progressively by following the financial trail from a victim complaint.

1. A victim reported a ₹1.04 lakh investment fraud to IV Town Police Station in Nizamabad.
2. Investigators identified a phone number associated with the fraudulent investment application and traced the payment to a bank account.
3. The receiving account was identified as a mule account and an immediate freeze was requested.
4. The account holder, Mohammad Abdul Jawed, was arrested and investigators recovered almost the entire amount lost by the Nizamabad victim.
5. Questioning identified Gudumala Nithish as a suspected handler.
6. Information associated with Nithish reportedly revealed 13 current accounts and ₹31.07 crore in linked cybercrime transactions.
7. Investigators broadened the bank-level search to current accounts opened between 2024 and 2026.
8. Of 106 accounts reviewed, 46 were reported as linked to cybercrime complaints on the NCRP.
9. Cross-state linkages showed that the accounts were connected to cybercrime cases across 14 states.

10. The investigation therefore expanded from a single victim complaint into a nationwide mule-account network.

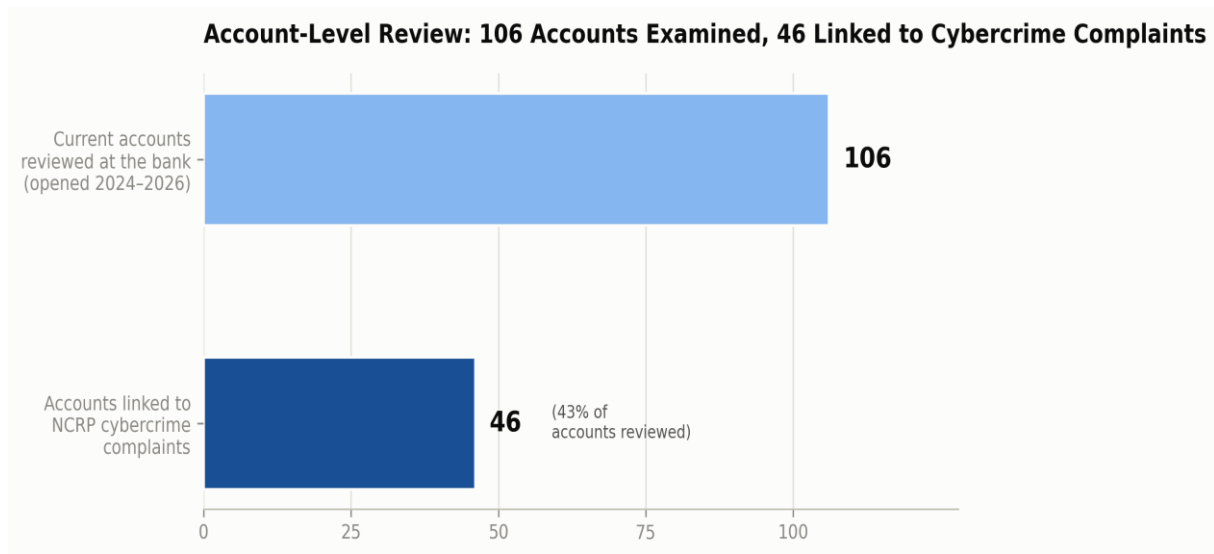


Figure 4. Of the 106 current accounts reviewed by police, 46 (43%) were linked to NCRP cybercrime complaints.

A missed earlier signal

The case also illustrates a limitation in fragmented fraud investigations. The key account had reportedly appeared in a June 2024 NCRP complaint involving a Noida investment fraud. A UP police officer told Indian Express that the investigation was not able to fully trace the account because it was registered outside the state and funds had moved through multiple accounts in different states. This suggests that the same financial identifier can be visible to different investigators without automatically producing a unified national picture.

8. How Was the Fraud Tackled?

8.1 Immediate response to the Nizamabad victim

- The receiving account was traced.
- Police requested an immediate account freeze.
- Almost the entire amount lost by the Nizamabad victim was reportedly recovered.
- The named account holder was arrested.
- Questioning was used to identify a suspected handler.

8.2 Broader network investigation

- The case was brought into the broader Telangana Cyber Security Bureau mule-account crackdown.
- Investigators examined account information associated with the suspected handler.
- Bank-level information was requested for current accounts opened over a defined period.
- Accounts were cross-referenced with cybercrime complaints recorded on the NCRP.
- Additional suspects and account holders were identified and arrested, while others remained to be traced.

- The investigation continued across jurisdictions because the underlying victims and transactions were distributed across states.

8.3 Why recovery was difficult

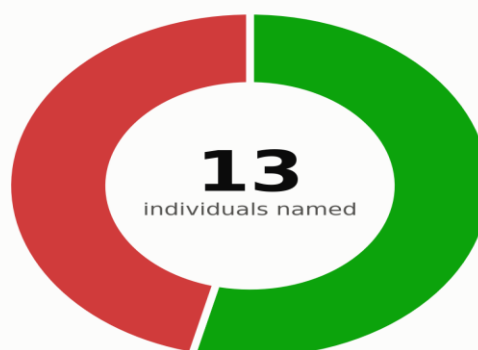
The case reports several victims who had not recovered their money because funds had already moved from the identified Nizamabad account to other accounts. This illustrates the importance of speed in cyber-fraud response: freezing the first receiving account can preserve funds, but once money is layered through several accounts, recovery becomes progressively harder.

9. Were the Perpetrators Caught?

The answer is: some were arrested, but the public record reviewed for this case does not support saying that the entire network was dismantled or that every perpetrator was identified.

Status	Documented position
Mohammad Abdul Jawed	Arrested in connection with the original Nizamabad complaint.
Gudumala Nithish	Arrested after being identified by investigators as Jawed's handler.
Other connected individuals	The detailed May 2026 Indian Express investigation reported seven individuals apprehended in connection with the fraudulent accounts.
Remaining account holders	The same report said six account holders were still absconding and efforts were underway to trace them.
Holder of key account 56820000100031001	Indian Express reported that the account was frozen and that a Nizamabad constable was still searching for its holder.
April 2026 related operation	Regional reports separately described 9 or 13 arrests in a related Nizamabad account-selling/mule-account operation. These figures should not be automatically merged with the seven-person count without case-file confirmation.
Overall case status	Ongoing investigation based on the public information reviewed; no final judicial outcome for the entire network was identified.

Documented Status of Named Suspects (May 2026 detailed investigation)



■ Apprehended — 7 (54%)
■ Reported absconding — 6 (46%)

Excludes the still-unidentified holder of the key account and any later-named suspects

Figure 5. Documented status of the 13 individuals named in the detailed May 2026 investigation.

A responsible academic conclusion is therefore: the investigation produced multiple arrests and account freezes, but the publicly available evidence indicates that some suspects remained untraced and the broader network had not reached a final judicial disposition by the research cut-off used here.

10. Fraud Analytics Perspective

Although this assignment does not require building a fraud-detection model, the investigation provides a real-world example of fraud analytics in an investigative sense. The police effectively used information from transactions, bank accounts, phones and cybercrime complaints to establish relationships between seemingly separate incidents.

10.1 Transaction tracing

The first analytical step was following the victim's payment into the receiving bank account. This is a basic but critical form of financial forensics: starting with a known fraudulent transaction and identifying where the money went next.

10.2 Account linkage

The investigation did not stop after identifying one account. Information associated with the suspected handler revealed additional current accounts. This transformed the investigation from a single-account problem into an account-network problem.

10.3 Cross-case correlation

The 46 accounts were compared with cybercrime complaints recorded on the NCRP. This is a crucial analytical step: an account that appears ordinary when viewed in isolation can become highly significant when it appears in multiple unrelated complaints.

10.4 Cross-jurisdictional analysis

The accounts were linked to cases in 14 states. The case demonstrates the analytical value of combining information across jurisdictions rather than treating each police-station complaint as an isolated event.

10.5 Network perspective

The investigation can be represented as a network of victims, fraud schemes, bank accounts, handlers and other accounts. The key account 56820000100031001 functioned as a node through which proceeds from multiple frauds passed. This network perspective explains why investigators were able to move from one victim to several apparently unrelated cases.

10.6 Important distinction

The above are analytical interpretations of the documented investigative process. They should not be presented as evidence that Telangana Police used a particular graph database, machine-learning algorithm, AI model or automated fraud score. The public reporting reviewed does not establish that.

11. Why Did the Fraud Scale?

- The victim-facing scams could use different narratives, allowing the underlying financial infrastructure to support multiple fraud types.
- Mule accounts separated the victim-facing fraudster from the bank account receiving the money.
- Funds could be transferred onward, making recovery more difficult after the first transaction.
- The network crossed state boundaries, creating investigative and coordination challenges.
- The same account could reportedly be used in connection with more than one criminal syndicate or fraud stream.
- An earlier complaint involving the key account did not immediately reveal the full network, illustrating the problem of fragmented information.
- Large numbers of current accounts created the potential to distribute suspicious activity across multiple identifiers.

12. Key Lessons from the Case

LESSON 1 Small losses can hide large networks

The original complaint involved ₹1.04 lakh, yet the subsequent investigation identified a network with ₹152.18 crore in linked transactions. The size of the first complaint was therefore a poor indicator of the size of the underlying network.

LESSON 2 The receiving account can be as important as the scam itself

Victim-facing fraud techniques changed across cases, but the money repeatedly entered mule accounts. Following the financial infrastructure therefore connected apparently unrelated scams.

LESSON 3 Cross-state data matters

The earlier Noida complaint demonstrates how jurisdictional boundaries can make account-level investigations fragmented. A bank account registered in one state can receive money from a victim in another state and send it to another account elsewhere.

LESSON 4 Speed matters for recovery

The Nizamabad victim's near-complete recovery was possible because police traced and froze the receiving account quickly. Other victims were reportedly unable to recover money because funds had already moved onward.

LESSON 5 A mule-account ecosystem can serve multiple fraud types

The central account was associated with investment fraud, impersonation and other cybercrime proceeds. Therefore, fraud investigations should examine the infrastructure behind a transaction rather than only the narrative used to deceive the victim.

LESSON 6 Arrests do not necessarily equal network dismantling

Even after multiple arrests, investigators continued searching for account holders and the holder of the central account. A fraud network can have several layers of participants, and identifying one layer does not necessarily identify the entire network.

13. Limitations and Source Reliability

- The detailed public reconstruction comes primarily from a May 2026 Indian Express investigation that quotes police officials and victims.
- The ₹152.18 crore number should be described as linked transaction value, not as the amount stolen from one victim or necessarily retained by one criminal group.
- The number of arrests varies across April 2026 regional reports because they appear to describe a related or overlapping Nizamabad mule-account operation. The figures should not be combined without access to the FIRs and case records.
- The public record does not establish a final judicial verdict for the entire network as of the research cut-off.
- The identities of several victims are anonymised in the detailed reporting; this case study preserves that approach.
- Police allegations and media descriptions of criminal roles should not be treated as final findings of guilt unless a court judgment establishes them.

14. Conclusion

The Nizamabad mule-account investigation demonstrates how a cyber-fraud case can evolve from an apparently isolated victim complaint into a much wider financial-crime investigation. The starting point was a ₹1.04 lakh investment fraud reported in January 2025. Investigators traced the money to a bank account, arrested the account holder and identified a suspected handler. The later examination of the handler's information and bank-account records exposed a broader structure.

According to the detailed May 2026 investigation, 106 current accounts were examined, 46 were linked to cybercrime complaints, the cases spanned 14 states, and the identified accounts were associated with approximately ₹152.18 crore in transactions. The same financial infrastructure was connected to multiple forms of fraud, including investment and impersonation scams.

The most important Fraud Analytics lesson is therefore not the use of a particular algorithm. It is the value of connecting financial events that appear unrelated when viewed individually. The case shows how transaction tracing, account linkage, complaint correlation and cross-jurisdictional investigation can reveal the structure behind seemingly separate fraud incidents. At the same time, the case illustrates the limits of fragmented data: an earlier complaint had already identified the central account, but the wider network was not immediately exposed.

As of the research cut-off of 18 September 2026, the public information reviewed indicates multiple arrests but also continuing efforts to trace remaining account holders and participants. The case should therefore be treated as an ongoing investigation rather than a completely closed fraud case.

15. One-Minute Case Summary for Presentation

“This case began with a ₹1.04 lakh investment-fraud complaint in Nizamabad in January 2025. Police traced the money to a mule bank account, arrested its holder and identified a suspected handler. The investigation later expanded during Telangana's 2026 mule-account crackdown. Information associated with the handler revealed 13 current accounts linked to ₹31.07 crore in cybercrime transactions. Police then examined 106 current accounts opened between 2024 and 2026 and reported that 46 were linked to cybercrime complaints across 14 states, involving approximately ₹152.18 crore in linked transactions. The case is significant for Fraud Analytics because the investigation moved from a single victim and transaction to account-level linkage and finally to a cross-state network. Several people were arrested, but some account holders remained untraced and the wider investigation had not reached a final judicial outcome in the public sources reviewed.”

16. References

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Appendix A: Case Facts vs. Analytical Interpretation

Statement	Category
₹1.04 lakh was lost by the Nizamabad complainant	Reported case fact
Account 56820000100031001 had appeared in a June 2024 NCRP complaint	Reported case fact
46 accounts were linked to cybercrime complaints	Reported investigation finding
The accounts were linked to cases in 14 states	Reported investigation finding
₹152.18 crore represents linked transaction value	Reported figure; interpretation clarified by case-study author

Statement	Category
The network should be visualised as a graph of victims, accounts and handlers	Academic analytical interpretation
Graph analytics / transaction scoring could potentially detect similar networks	General analytical concept; not claimed as used in this investigation
All arrested individuals are guilty	Not established; arrests are not convictions